

Reimagine HR Self-Service With AI Technologies

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By: Ron Hanscome, Alex Chertoff

Initiatives: Technologies and Markets

AI-enabled self-service technologies can substantially improve employee, manager and leader experience, but no single solution will fit every organization. CHROs must harmonize the data, technology, measurement and skills factors that drive successful AI self-service solution selection and deployment.

Overview

Key Findings

- Most (60%) HR technology leaders report facing insufficient data governance when using data for decision making. Similarly, only 14% of IT leaders are very confident that their content and data are ready for AI and human interactions.
- Three-quarters of HR technology leaders have implemented employee self-service portals, and 69% plan to increase their specific HR technology investment in GenAI and AI applications.
- Compared to last year, 62% of HR technology leaders report being under more pressure to show benefits and ROI from HR tech and services spending.
- A majority (59%) of CHROs agree that limited digital skills prevent HR from evolving into an AI-first operation.

Recommendations

- Develop and maintain AI-ready data by implementing data cleansing and content governance initiatives as a prerequisite for deploying any self-service technology.
- Improve self-service effectiveness and adoption by fitting emerging technologies to workforce needs and business objectives, not vice versa.
- Demonstrate the business value of self-service solutions by establishing targeted KPIs, using real-time user feedback to continuously optimize tools, and tracking change over time.
- Equip HR talent to own, design and optimize self-service solutions by developing HR product management skills and mindsets in the function.

Gartner's Take

Deploying HR self-service technology will degrade rather than enhance employee experience unless HR makes its data AI-ready and redesigns processes to match technology options to the organization's unique workforce needs.

Introduction

As organizations focus on cost optimization, CHROs are under pressure to improve the business value from HR technology implementations. Self-service solutions can decrease HR costs by handling administrative and operational HR delivery at scale while simultaneously freeing up HR staff's time for more strategic tasks.

Three-quarters of HR technology leaders state their organization has already implemented employee self-service portals. ¹ Still, 74% of CHROs report that heavy transactional demands restrict the HR function from offering more strategic support. ² This highlights an opportunity for CHROs to promote self-service redesign and mature its use for decreased cost and increased strategic impact.

A range of HR technology functions is involved in administrative and operational self-service (see Figure 1). Emerging AI technologies (such as HR virtual assistants, generative AI and agentic AI) ³ promise to improve the employee, manager and administrator self-service experience. However, implementation and adoption can prove challenging for organizations navigating an evolving technology landscape that is often composed of fragmented and incomplete data.

Figure 1: HR Technology Functions Included in Administrative and Operational Self-Service

HR Technology Functions Included in Administrative and Operational Self-Service

■ Capabilities that span the HCM suite ■ Functions typically included in administrative and operational self-service ■ Other HR technology functions	Conversational user interfaces (e.g., HR virtual assistants, AI agents, agentic AI)				
	Skills management				
	Administrative HR	Talent management	Workforce management	Integrated HR service management	Employee experience and engagement management
	Core HR data & life cycle transactions	Recruiting	Time and attendance	Policy and procedure guidance	Voice of the employee
	Position and organization management	Onboarding	Absence management	HR knowledge base	Personalization of user experience
	Payroll administration	Performance and goals management	Workforce scheduling	HR contact center	Employee life cycle journeys and workflow management
	Benefits administration	Career planning	Task and activity management	HR case management	Employee well-being
	Employee and manager self-service	Succession planning	Labor forecasting	Employee relations case management	Rewards and recognition
	Occupational health and safety	Learning	Fatigue management	HR document management	
	Expense management	Compensation management	Other timekeeping use cases (e.g., T&E)		
	People analytics				
	Workforce planning				

Source: Gartner 840618

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Addressing foundational data issues is the crucial first step in reimagining HR self-service. Follow this and other steps to prepare both the HR function and the workforce to reap the full benefits of AI-enabled administrative and operational self-service:

- Develop and maintain AI-ready data.
- Fit emerging self-service technologies to workforce needs and business objectives, not vice versa.
- Measure and continuously improve the impact of self-service.
- Develop HR product management skills and mindsets.

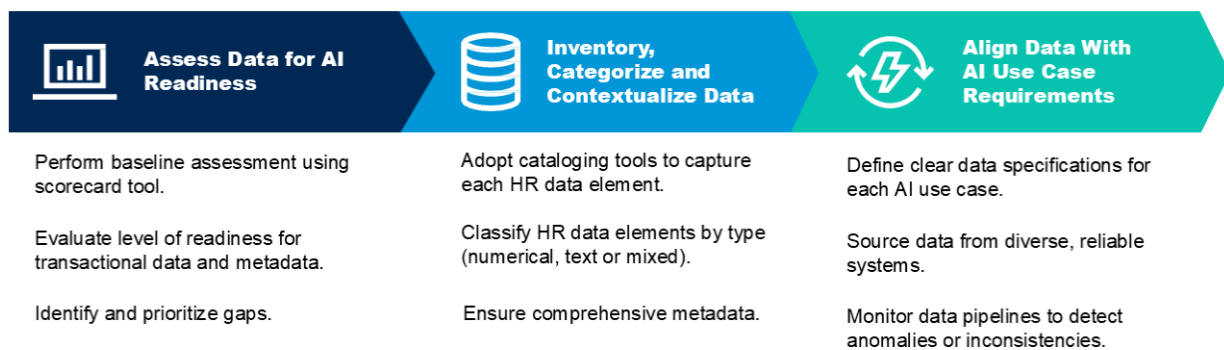
Analysis

Develop and Maintain AI-Ready Data

Resist the temptation to simply “throw technology at the problem” as a reflex reaction to HR self-service support issues. For all the promise and potential of emerging AI technologies, one time-honored principle must take precedence: “garbage in, garbage out.” Clean and accurate data throughout the HR technology portfolio is essential for achieving desired self-service process outcomes. Use Gartner’s suggested approach to building AI-ready data as a template for comparison with any current initiatives (see Figure 2).

Figure 2: 3-Step Process for Building AI-Ready HR Data

3-Step Process for Building AI-Ready HR Data



Source: Gartner
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While this three-step process is generally applicable (see [How HR Tech Leaders Can Make HR Data AI-Ready](#) for full details), confirm that any data quality initiative addresses some unique aspects related to self-service:

- **Structured data** — Project teams must ensure that both current and historical data include the proper context that gives that data meaning (such as job titles, department names and reporting relationships). This context may be incomplete or absent, particularly for organizations that have grown through mergers and acquisitions and sacrificed data conversion completeness for speed. Project teams should allocate time and budget to remediate missing or incomplete data.

- **Unstructured data** — Many operational self-service HR processes (such as contextual policy and procedure guidance, and benefits administration) rely on unstructured data that may reside in documents on company intranets. Gartner client inquiries indicate that content governance and curation are typically limited, resulting in duplicate policies that contain inconsistent or conflicting information. This scenario increases the risk that self-service AI technologies leveraging this unstructured data will give inaccurate responses to employee queries. Confirm that any improvement project identifies and removes outdated policy/procedure documents, so that new technologies can begin with a clean and accurate dataset.
- **Content curation** — Mandate that project teams incorporate content curation best practices into the implementation and ongoing management of any new solutions. This includes maintaining content metadata, such as beginning and end dates and eligibility rules. It should also involve notifying content owners of pending content expiration to prompt reviews and updates, ensuring content remains current. Additionally, the solution should have automated expiration rules that remove outdated content as needed.

Ensure that these data management and content governance concepts are embedded into HR technology management practices and operational culture to minimize the risk of data quality degradation.

Fit AI Technologies to the Workforce, Not Vice Versa

CHROs must next drive a robust evaluation of AI technologies to determine which offerings are best suited to improve self-service for the organization. With every vendor forcefully proclaiming its current AI capabilities and near-term roadmap enhancement plans, arriving at a best-fit solution is a complex endeavor that is made even more difficult by rapid product evolution. Evaluation teams should weigh the following principles to help build a shortlist of potential alternatives for detailed examination.

Evaluate Incumbent Providers First

Most organizations already have a substantial HR technology portfolio. Before jumping straight to AI point solutions or self-development, first evaluate your incumbent vendors for their ability to meet your needs, as this may potentially reduce subscription fees and integration costs. Typical solutions that are improving HR self-service with extensive AI roadmaps include:

- **HCM suites** — These solutions have always included transactional employee and manager self-service. Many have delivered integrated HR service management (IHRSM) modules that enhance the overall employee and manager experience (see [Critical Capabilities for HCM Suites for 1,000+ Employee Enterprises](#) for details).
- **IHRSM solutions** — These applications have either expanded into IHRSM from other domains (such as IT or customer service management), or focus specifically on IHRSM (see [Market Guide for Integrated HR Service Management Solutions](#) for details).
- **Workforce management (WFM) applications** — Enterprises with many hourly-paid workers typically invest in either the WFM module of their HCM suite or a point solution focused on their industry. Regardless, hourly workers interact with these applications daily and view them as their primary employee experience. While the depth of capabilities varies, the transactional nature of WFM processes is well-suited to the automation and efficiency-focused improvements enabled by AI (see the [Market Guide for Workforce Management Applications](#) for details).

Incumbent enterprise AI capabilities may also exist outside the HR technology portfolio. For example, an organization with mostly desk workers using a digital workplace tool like Microsoft Teams for their daily work may also need to evaluate Microsoft Copilot. Others may have deployed an enterprise portal using an intranet packaged solution and will need to evaluate its depth of AI enablement. Getting to the right mix of vendors requires partnering with enterprise IT and senior stakeholders to determine and prioritize evaluation criteria.

Prioritize Capabilities That Fit Your Industry and Workers While Embracing Process Redesign

Keeping the needs of your industry and worker types firmly in mind is another key consideration when evaluating potential solutions (both incumbent and new). For example, an operational function like WFM's AI readiness and appeal to the workforce in a professional services firm will differ significantly from a manufacturing environment. The former will welcome an AI agent that will help them complete their weekly time sheet and expense report for client billing and utilization. At the same time, those on the manufacturing line are more likely to embrace more efficient shift bid/swap features.

However, avoid painting the workforce with too broad a brush, as there will be variation among various types of hourly workers. Instead, work with operational leaders to segment the workforce and then analyze each segment to build a holistic picture of how to redesign processes to fully leverage new AI features. The good news is that many established solutions have begun to focus more on industry nuances, so ask your incumbents for any planned features that target your industry.

Don't Forget to Address Administrator Pain Points

While your primary focus should be on improving direct employee and manager self-service capabilities, ensure that evaluation teams fully develop their vendor evaluation criteria by also documenting administrator requirements and current pain points. Vendors have begun streamlining HR administration with GenAI, such as:

- Ingesting existing policy and procedure documents and converting them to knowledge article “drafts” for reviewing, editing and approval by administrative staff to reduce implementation time and streamline ongoing knowledge base management.
- Providing an AI assistant that delivers an initial configuration based on core organizational data for further iteration and testing by the implementation team.
- Delivering “always-on” AI agents that proactively analyze IHRS process metrics and notify administrators of potential process bottlenecks or high knowledge article abandonment rates.

Make Pilots the Rule, Not the Exception

Gartner generally recommends a piloting approach to deploying enterprise applications, and AI technologies are no exception. Pilots of emerging AI technologies work best in an organizational subsegment whose leader embraces the potential business value, and where employees and managers are change-ready. Confirm that project teams are using pilots to drive increased adoption of new capabilities over the medium to long term. For one approach to tracking and managing pilots, see the [Tool: Evaluation Guide for Structuring an HR Pilot Pipeline](#).

Measure and Continuously Improve Self-Service's Impact

Measure the Impact of Self-Service

To solidify the business case for continued investment in self-service technologies, measure and communicate their effectiveness. Use a holistic approach to measuring self-service's impact that captures value at all levels:

- **Adoption outcomes** — Track usage as a baseline indicator of engagement. Adoption metrics help the HR identify patterns in utilization across the talent life cycle and employee segments.
- **Experience outcomes** — Use metrics such as net promoter score (NPS) and user satisfaction to assess how employees experience self-service platforms.
- **Functional outcomes** — Compare metrics such as containment rate and the percentage of inquiries resolved without escalation to HR service centers or business partners against cost per resolution in HR service centers to highlight self-service's impact on HR cost and delivery. Metrics like attempts per unique user can also provide insight into usability and resolution effectiveness.
- **Quality outcomes** — HR must also track quality outcomes, such as error, data accuracy and first contact resolution rates. HR is responsible for providing channels to escalate issues about AI outputs and accuracy, and should provide targeted follow-up support to end users who report errors.

These metrics categories enable CHROs to communicate self-service outcomes within the context of broader HR transformation objectives. Clearly linking self-service performance to strategic goals helps CHROs secure stakeholder support and demonstrates the value of investments in HR technology (see [How CHROs Can Effectively Communicate the Value of HR Technology](#) for more guidance).

Continuously Improve Self-Service Solutions

Use the metrics your teams collect to drive improvement. To ensure issues with self-service don't slip through the cracks, establish processes for addressing employee feedback. These may include scheduled reviews of feedback data, which includes quality outcome metrics, rapid response protocols for emerging issues and extended periods of hypercare when deploying new features.

Organizations can leverage AI-driven voice of the employee (VoE) capabilities to capture real-time feedback on satisfaction and surface pain points. Sources such as pulse surveys, focus groups and collaboration tool data can surface where employees abandon self-service processes, revealing critical friction points in the user journey. For example, AI-enabled focus groups can connect qualitative user sentiment to patterns in abandonment outcomes, highlighting targeted areas for improvement. HR technology teams can explore incumbent VoE solutions and strengthen feedback loops to improve self-service.

Develop HR Product Management Skills and Mindsets

As AI automates administrative tasks, focus on upskilling HR talent and equipping them to optimize self-service HR technology. Aim to embed product management skills and mindsets in HR, supporting effective collaboration between HR, IT and vendors. This requires developing HR talent that can apply user-centric thinking across the entire product life cycle.

Key principles to effectively manage HR self-service solutions as a product, rather than a project, include:

- **Long-term commitment** to improving self-service and AI solutions over time.
- **People-centricity**, meaning the human roles and their processes are as important as the self-service and AI technologies.
- **Permanent staffing**, beyond short-term outsourcing, to support changes with skilled personnel who have the resources to iterate on self-service and AI solutions.

Bring in talent with nontraditional HR experience as needed to infuse HR with a product-oriented mindset. See [Case Study: Transforming L&D With Tech-Enabled Collective Learning \(Genpact\)](#) for an example of how HR can successfully introduce dedicated product management roles into the function.

Evidence

¹ **Optimizing HR Technology Survey:** This survey was conducted to understand the use of HR technology for cost optimization. The survey also explored the roles and responsibilities of HR technology leaders in implementing and communicating the benefits within the HR function and the wider organization. The research was conducted online from 26 March through 24 April 2025 among 48 HR technology leaders from different geographies and industries. The survey was designed and developed by Gartner's HR practice research team. Disclaimer: The results of this survey do not represent global findings or the market as a whole, but reflect the sentiments of the respondents and companies surveyed.

² **2026 Gartner HR Priorities Survey:** This survey was conducted to understand senior HR leader perspectives on their priorities and challenges for the next 12 to 18 months. The survey was conducted online from 6 June 2025 through 18 July 2025 and contains responses from 900 HR leaders with representation from various regions and industries. Disclaimer: The results of this survey do not represent global findings or the market as a whole, but reflect the sentiments of the respondents and companies surveyed.

³ See [Hype Cycle for HR Technology, 2025](#) for detailed definitions of these innovations.

Recommended by the Authors

Some documents may not be available as part of your current Gartner subscription.

[How HR Tech Leaders Can Make HR Data AI-Ready](#)

[3 Steps to Establish AI-Ready HR Data](#)

[7 Hacks to Boost HR Technology Adoption](#)

[Framework for Evaluating AI Capabilities in HCM Suites](#)

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